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Darryl Settles launched the annual Lower Roxbury/South End Jazz Festival, set for this month.

A new kind of urban gentry

▶ NEWCOMERS
Continued from Page 1

The Hill in Pittsburgh.

As in other neighborhoods throughout Boston, the newcomers and first-generation Bostonians are burnishing a town known for tradition, even splashing it on canvas. (The work of some of these newcomers will be displayed alongside that of longtimers next month at the fourth annual Roxbury Open Studios.)

"It's important for folks who are on a progressive career path to stay in predominantly black communities, to help make sure that 'black community' doesn't stay synonymous with 'poor communities,'" says Brooklyn native Granderson, sitting in his 11-room 1915 Colonial house on the Roxbury-Dorchester divide, a few blocks from Franklin Park.

His house is also home to Inner City Software, where he and six other employees work on projects such as www.roxbury.com (an online community bulletin board with news of events and happenings in the area that launched earlier this year) and Boston Blacks Online, an online cafe with more than 4,000 members globally. As Granderson paces around his conference room, which was a bedroom in a previous incarnation, he says, "There is no reason that middle-class folks have to stay outside of the city. I never understood why gentrification always had to be white folks from the suburbs moving into the city. Why can't it be black folks?"

Blacks such as Granderson represent a small dispersal of middle-class folks who are returning to or discovering such historic neighborhoods. Many transplant themselves here in search of a colorful past they saw — or wished they had seen — in their native communities as children.

Although recent housing figures track migrations of black middle-class families moving to the suburbs nationwide, there is "a small inward movement" back into the cities," says Gary Orfield, a professor of education and social policy at Harvard University who has studied housing through The Civil Rights Project. It's a scene — some call it black gentrification — that is being played out around the country in historic neighborhoods in Chicago, Pittsburgh, Washington and New York City.

"It's healthy," says Orfield. "These are areas that should be redeveloped. They are potential treasures for the city. Why not move into an area full of historic houses, that is close to the city and has all the infrastructures?"

It's a trend realtor Elisa Daley has seen firsthand, showing black professionals available properties in Roxbury as well as Dorchester. "Black professionals know what is going on in the city," said Daley, who has sold several buildings and town houses to singles and families in the burgeoning Roxbury Fort Hill area. "Its wonderful to see the professional people building in the Fort Hill area and recognizing the value. The rest of Roxbury is coming."

The second annual Lower Roxbury/South End Jazz Festival runs from noon to 6 p.m. Sept. 28. The festival will be held on Columbus Avenue between Massachusetts Avenue and Melnea Cass Boulevard. About 30,000 people are expected to attend the free event. Four stages will feature 18 jazz acts, including Stan Strickland, Myanna, The Boston Horns and The Paulo Danay Quartet.

Whites and other ethnic groups are also discovering the area, and although some welcome the diversity, others worry that gentrification may reduce the supply of affordable housing. Last month, a group of residents of Roxbury's Highland Park protested the potential sale of a low-income town house complex to a condo developer. "If the sale goes through," said one tenant at the protest, "residents here won't be able to afford condos and we'll be forced to leave our homes."

On Tuesday, on a section of Moreland Street off Dudley Square, two homes were leveled for green space despite opposition from some neighbors, who decried the move as another step toward gentrification.

Granderson hopes such tensions throughout Roxbury can be worked out and a balance found as older residents try to hang on to their homes while black professionals move into historic black pockets to try and rebuild them.

"If you come in with an individualistic mindset, you would have removed the area's soul," said Granderson.

In dreams about his utopian neighborhood, Granderson sees a consortium of black professionals buying up properties in historic black areas and collaborating with veteran residents so they could maintain their homes and revel in the area's urban renewal with the newcomers.

"I would hope that more black professionals would recognize the power that comes moving into neighborhoods where little kids see you and think, 'This person looks like me and is a stock broker or a doctor on my block,'" said Granderson, who is looking to launch dorchester.com and mattapan.com in projects he sees as "breaking the virtual ice."

"People emulate that which they look up to," he says. "If you remove your upper echelon of accomplishment from your area, who could blame kids for not emulating that" — and moving away themselves when they reach adulthood.

A few miles away in Fort Hill, Sean Daughtry recalls telling his fellow Cambridge chemists that he and his wife Chenita bought their Roxbury home. Talk about combustible!

"They were like, 'Roxbury!'" says Daughtry, a native of North Carolina. "I was like, 'Yes — we want to live in the city and we want to be around people who look like us to a certain degree.' You have to be selective to find your own culture," said Daughtry. He found that in a Fort Hill town house, in a neighborhood where his 15-month-old daughter's day-care school is just a half-mile distant. He enjoys watching the bright glow of Fenway Park from his balcony when the Red Sox are in town. He climbs up Highland Park with his family to gaze at sweeping vistas of the Hub.

"We wanted to live in the black community," adds Chenita Daughtry. "We didn't want to go to the suburbs. I like the fact that Roxbury is a historic black neighborhood. It felt like home."

Home for her had been a predominantly black Louisiana neighborhood where folks sat on their porches and the kids all knew one another. "We were looking to have a neighborhood like that," she said.

Around the corner from their Fort Hill town house is Darryl Settles, the jazz promoter and owner of Bob the Chef's soul food restaurant on the Roxbury/South End border. A native of Aiken, S.C., a sleepy town Settles compares to Natick, Settles had lived in Framingham, Stow, Hudson and the South End until he heard about an available property in Roxbury.

He bought it on the spot. "It's close to the city and you are not paying $1 million to live here," says Settles, as he weaved up and down Fort Hill's meandering streets in his convertible on a recent Friday, waving to neighbors on the brick porches of town houses on Fort Avenue.

'They were like, "Roxbury!" I was like, "Yes — we want to live in the city and we want to be around people who look like us to a certain degree." '
SEAN DAUGHTRY, native of North Carolina

Nearby, at the intersection of Columbus Avenue and Tremont Street, a sign touts the jazz festival that Settles launched last year to commemorate the area's jazz heyday in the 1940s and 1950s, when Billie Holiday, Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong, Ella Fitzgerald, Fats Waller, and Bill (Bojangles) Robinson played clubs such as the Hi-Hat, Savoy, Connolly's, Estelle's, the Pioneer Club and Storyville.

The festival raises money to benefit neighborhood groups such as Community Servings, which provides hot meals for low-income residents and people homebound with HIV. Last year, 20,000 people attended, and Settles expects 30,000 will turn out this year for the fest on Sept. 28.

"There are people who are making a difference, who are doing well and are still living in the community," Settles says as he looks over Roxbury from the top of Fort Hill. "You can make changes in an area and build on it. I am only helping. I am showing what Boston can be."

Johnny Diaz may be reached at jodiaz@globe.com.

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The out-of-towners

A few Roxbury powers, where they came from, and what they do:

Chuck Turner	Cincinnati	City Councilor
Darryl Settles	South Carolina	Owner, Bob the Chef's, jazz festival impresario
Chenita Daughtry	Louisiana	IBM software engineer
Kenneth Granderson	New York	Founder, roxbury.com
Ed Bullins	Philadelphia	Playwright

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